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15 ways to end screen time without tears

Why the tears come: apps and shows hand out quick, easy rewards, and most have no natural finish line. When the screen goes dark, Dopa (our cartoon for the brain's "want more" chemical) suddenly loses its easy stars. Nothing is wrong with your kid. The ending just needs a plan.

Before the screen goes on

1. **Set the ending before it starts.** "Two episodes, then we turn it off together." An ending agreed in advance isn't a surprise. [10]
2. **Pick a finish line.** An episode, a level, a song. Not a feed. Turn autoplay off so the next video doesn't start by itself. [1] [2]
3. **Use a timer they can see.** A kitchen timer or a sand timer next to the screen. The timer ends it, not you. [10] [11]
4. **Agree where you land next.** A snack, a small job, a game outside. Going *to* something is easier than leaving something. [10]

When it's time to stop

5. **Warn twice.** At 5 minutes and at 1 minute. Some families use 10 and 2. Pick one and keep it. [10] [11]
6. **Break the spell first.** Touch a shoulder and wait for eye contact before you say anything. Words don't reach a kid who's still inside the screen.
7. **Offer a small choice.** "Do you want to turn it off, or should I?" A choice gives back a little control. [11]
8. **Name the feeling, keep the limit.** "Two things are true: screen time is over, and you're allowed to be upset." [27]
9. **Say less.** One short sentence, repeated, in a calm voice. No lecture while feelings are big. Stay close. [11] [12]
10. **Don't give it back to stop the crying.** And don't debate a rule you've already set. Pushback often fades within a week or two of steady endings. [10]

Around the day

11. **Same ending, every day.** Same time, same words, same next step. Kids handle limits better when they can predict them. [11]
12. **Screens off about an hour before bed.** Bright light in the evening can push sleepiness later, even in young kids. [1] [13]
13. **Devices sleep outside the bedroom.** Phones and tablets charge in the kitchen overnight, parents' too. [1] [23]

14. **Make an "instead" list together.** Ten things to do that aren't screens, written by your kid, on the fridge. [10]
15. **Go first.** Put your own phone away at meals and when screen time ends. With teens, make a deal, not a rule: write a family media plan together. [1] [2]

Talk to your pediatrician if screens crowd out sleep, school, friends or family life even with steady limits, or if screen time comes with big mood changes.

Educational only, not medical advice. The crew are cartoon metaphors, not measurements. More short explainers at littlebraincrew.com · hello@littlebraincrew.com

Sources

Numbers in brackets in the text, like [13], point to this list. We keep every claim no bigger than the research behind it; where the research is in adults or is an association, we say so.

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